

Djokovic Rallies and Sabalenka Wins at China Open

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Novak Djokovic came back from a set down to win at the China Open in Beijing. The 39-year-old Serb beat China's Bu Yunchaokete 4-6, 7-6 (7-2), 6-2 in two hours and 52 minutes.

Djokovic has won the tournament six times and has won all 31 matches he has played in Beijing. Bu made this match difficult for him. In the second set, Djokovic lost a service game after taking a lead and needed a medical timeout. He received a time violation while trying to regain his breath between points. He also consulted a trainer, as he had during his first-round win over Nuno Borges.

Djokovic then won the tie-break 7-2. In the **deciding** set, he won four games in a row and finished the match with a backhand winner. He will face either Germany's Alexander Zverev or China's Shang Juncheng on Saturday for a place in the quarter-finals.

In the women's event, world number two Aryna Sabalenka began with a 6-1, 6-3 victory over Mexico's Renata Zarazua. Sabalenka hit 11 **aces** and did not face a **break point**. The match lasted 63 minutes.

It was her first match since losing her world number one ranking and her US Open title to Elena Rybakina in September. Sabalenka is seeking her first title since March, when she won Indian Wells and the Miami Open back-to-back.

Asked about being **self-critical**, Sabalenka explained that expecting more from herself sometimes helps her move forward, but sometimes drains her energy. She said she is trying to be easier on herself.

Sabalenka will next face Czech 20-year-old Nikola Bartunkova, who came close to beating her at the Berlin Open in June. Rybakina, the top **seed**, begins her tournament on Saturday.

Elsewhere, Katie Boulter lost to Karolina Muchova. Mirra Andreeva recovered from losing the first set to beat Yuan Yue 3-6, 6-0, 6-0. Daniil Medvedev hit 12 **aces** to beat Pablo Carreno Busta 6-4, 6-2. British pair Julian Cash and Lloyd Glasspool beat Andrey Rublev and Karen Khachanov in **doubles**.

Word Treasure

deciding -- Determining the final result.

aces -- Serves that win points without the opponent touching the ball.

break point -- A point that would let the receiving player win the server's game.

self-critical -- Often judging your own actions or performance harshly.

seed -- A player given a tournament position based on ranking or expected strength.

doubles -- Tennis played by two teams of two players.

Background you need

A service game is a game in which one player serves. Losing that game is called being broken.

A tie-break uses a separate points format to decide a tied set.

Break it down

The opening reports Djokovic's comeback, score and match length.

The next section describes his record, medical timeout and deciding set.

The article shifts to Sabalenka's result and recent tournament history.

Her comments explain the effects of being self-critical.

The closing gives upcoming opponents and other match results.

Why it matters

The article follows two players advancing at the China Open. Djokovic's comeback illustrates how a match can change after the first set, while Sabalenka explains the mixed effects of demanding more from herself.

Test what you remember

1. How did Djokovic finish the match?

- ☐ (A) With a winning volley
- ☐ (B) With a winning serve
- ☐ (C) With a backhand winner
- ☐ (D) With a forehand winner

2. What was Djokovic's tie-break score?

- ☐ (A) 7-2
- ☐ (B) 7-3
- ☐ (C) 6-4
- ☐ (D) 6-2

3. What will Djokovic play for in his next match?

- ☐ (A) A place in the semi-finals
- ☐ (B) A place in the quarter-finals
- ☐ (C) A place in the doubles final
- ☐ (D) A place in the tournament final

4. Which tournaments did Sabalenka win back-to-back in March?

- ☐ (A) Indian Wells and the Miami Open
- ☐ (B) The Berlin Open and the China Open
- ☐ (C) The Miami Open and the China Open
- ☐ (D) Indian Wells and the Berlin Open

5. How did Sabalenka describe being self-critical?

- ☐ (A) It can motivate her or drain her energy.
- ☐ (B) It always helps her win every match.
- ☐ (C) It lets her avoid difficult opponents.
- ☐ (D) It has no effect on how she plays.

6. Who recovered from losing the first set to beat Yuan Yue?

- ☐ (A) Katie Boulter
- ☐ (B) Mirra Andreeva
- ☐ (C) Aryna Sabalenka
- ☐ (D) Karolina Muchova

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Aryna Sabalenka: She said her high expectations sometimes push her forward and sometimes drain her energy. She is working on being easier on herself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):